

The American and British transport aircraft based in northern India not only had to supply Allied troops, but also, after the Japanese cut off the “Burma Road,” became the only means of supplying the Chinese Nationalists and supporting US forces holed up in southwest China. Between 1942 and 1945, every single vehicle, weapon, round of ammunition, or drum of fuel was delivered “over the hump” from Dinjan in Assam across the Himalayas to Kunming. This was generally recognized as the most demanding route flown by transport aircraft anywhere during the war – a journey of 500 miles (800km) that took the C-47s, C-54s, and other transport planes over mountain ridges more than 16,000ft (5,000m) high.

If they hugged the mountain valleys, pilots ran into violent turbulence; if they put on their oxygen masks and flew high, they risked severe icing. During the monsoon season, dense cloud engulfed mountain ridges and valleys alike; pilots mostly flew on instruments, without sight of the ground, for the entire length of the journey. Flying the hump cost hundreds of aircrew their lives – the route was strewn with the wreckage – yet some 700,000 tons of supplies were delivered by the war’s end. Nor was the experience necessarily a grim one for airmen. One RAF pilot recorded the exhilaration of flying a Dakota over the Himalayan peaks on a moonlit night, with his radio tuned to a fine program of classical music from the BBC.

WINTER WAR

Soviet ground-crew members load up a bomber under the trying conditions of the Russian winter. The aircraft is a British-built Handley Page Hampden twin-engined bomber in Soviet markings.



FLYING THE HUMP

A C-47 flies the India-to-China supply route over the Himalayas. Operating a transport service across some of the world's most unforgiving terrain was an unprecedented challenge. At the cost of many lives Allied airmen proved that it could be done, keeping the Chinese Nationalist forces supplied with food, fuel, and munitions.

Russian winter

The most inhospitable environment in which any fliers had to operate was Russia in winter. The Luftwaffe, like the German army in general, was poorly prepared for the challenge of temperatures as low as -58°F (-50°C). Hard snow did not make a bad landing surface, but keeping aircraft operational was a nightmare. Fuel tanks and engine lubricant froze, hydraulic pumps broke down, rubber tires went brittle and cracked, flight instruments and radios refused to function. Often as few as one in four aircraft was fit to fly.

Yet under these conditions the Luftwaffe achieved some notable feats of air supply. At Demyansk in the winter of 1941–42, an army of 100,000 soldiers that had been encircled by the Soviets was kept supplied for three months by a fleet of Ju 52s and bombers, pressed into service as transport aircraft. But the following winter Hitler's demand that the Luftwaffe repeat this achievement at Stalingrad was simply beyond its capability. The 250,000 men of General Paulus'

Sixth Army, trapped in Stalingrad by Soviet forces in November 1942, needed an airlift of at least 300 tons of supplies a day to survive. At best the Luftwaffe managed a third of this total, and on many days they could deliver nothing at all.

Stalingrad airlift

For German airmen the Stalingrad airlift developed into an epic of personal heroism, collective suffering, and organizational chaos. Despite the bitter cold, both ground and aircrews lived in makeshift unheated shelters, alongside airstrips that came under repeated Soviet air attack. The hastily assembled transport fleet consisted chiefly of Ju 52s and Heinkel 111 bombers, but also included a motley collection of training and communications aircraft, and even 18 four-engined Focke-Wulf Condors. Working in the open in the snow and ice, ground crews struggled around the clock to make these aircraft flyable – on occasion mechanics were frozen fast to an engine as they tried to service it. Pilots routinely took off and landed in almost zero visibility. During the flight to Stalingrad's Pitomnek airstrip and back, the transport aircraft were harassed by Soviet fighters and flak. They sometimes landed under artillery fire, dodging wrecked aircraft and craters.

Harrowing incidents abounded: the transport plane packed with wounded soldiers that crashed immediately after takeoff, apparently because the wounded had slid to the back of the plane as it rose; or the last-minute evacuation of Tazinskaya airstrip as it was overrun by Soviet tanks, in which a third of a fleet of 180 Ju 52s were lost, many crashing into their own colleagues as escape descended into chaos.